

The Australian Government is investing in our forest and wood products industries' research and innovation capacity to deliver Australian made solutions to national challenges.

In partnership with the University of Tasmania (UTAS), the Australian Government has established an Australia-wide National Institute for Forest Products Innovation, under the operational name of Australian Forest and Wood Innovations (AFWI). AFWI will receive over \$100 million in funding from the Australian Government between 2022-23 to 2026-27.

AFWI is headquartered at UTAS's Newnham campus in Launceston and is supported by three regional Research Centres, UTAS Launceston, the University of the Sunshine Coast and the University of Melbourne.

The AFWI Board oversees all AFWI activities. The Board is supported by a Research Advisory Committee.

AFWI aims to put Australia's forest and wood products industries on the front foot, supporting applied research, development and innovation.

It creates opportunities for innovation and commercialisation of new knowledge.

It also provides opportunities to develop researchers in forest and wood products industries and associated research areas.

AFWI Headquarters, based at UTAS, is the administrative centre that coordinate research undertaken by 3 regional Research Centres. Research funding is available through an annual National Open Call and research commissioned through the Research Centres.

Details on the Research Centres and National Open Call are available on the [AFWI website](#).

The AFWI Board oversees all AFWI activities. They operate in an advisory capacity and endorse the strategic direction and research priorities of AFWI. The AFWI Board provides strategic direction and advice in relation to AFWI's program of activities and ensures that all research undertaken by AFWI is supported by industry.

The Board members are:

- Mr Bob Gordon (Chair)
- Ms Diana Gibbs
- Ms Christine Briggs
- Dr Heidi Dungey
- Mr Brian Farmer
- Ms Rachael Cavanagh
- Mr Andrew Leighton
- Prof Julianne O'Reilly-Wapstra
- Mr Andrew Wilson

The Board is supported by a Research Advisory Committee.

Three Research Centres have been established under AFWI to undertake forestry research and development. One of the Research Centres is based at UTAS in Launceston. The Australian Government identified the University of the Sunshine Coast and the University of Melbourne as the other two centres through a competitive expression of interest (EOI) process.

Additional detail on the Research Centres can be found on UTAS's [AFWI website](#).

There are 2 types of research funding available through AFWI:

- Research Centre funding
- National Open Call funding.

Each Research Centre will receive:

- \$9.8 million in Core Research Centre Funding. Core Funding does not require matching co-contributions, but still requires industry support.
- \$14.67 million in Conditional Research Centre Funding. Conditional research funding requires matching co-contributions and support from industry.

Research activities undertaken by Research Centres will be identified through consultation with industry at both local and national levels. Research Centres will be undertaking additional consultation in the coming months.

\$20 million is available for the National Open Calls for research. The open calls will be run across four \$5 million rounds. This funding is available to support projects proposed from anywhere in Australia that support Australia's forest and wood products industries. Projects submitted for consideration under the open calls are required to have matching co-contributions.

The next National Open Call will be announced on the [AFWI website](#), through media releases, and communicated in the forestry industry press.

Matching co-contributions can be cash or in-kind, and can be from industry, or other organisations. Commonwealth funding from other sources cannot be used as matching co-contributions.

All proposed projects, either through Research Centres or the National Open Calls, will be assessed by the Research Advisory Committee (a committee made up of industry and scientific members) to ensure that there is clear industry support and no duplication of research activities.

Each research centre will have specialised research themes, however they may work jointly with other Research Centres on themes.

Examples of the anticipated research themes that AFWI may address are outlined below.

AFWI's research focus will also be informed by the [AFWI strategic plan](#) and industry engagement.

Climate change solutions

Forestry and forest products have the potential to support the goal of a net zero emissions economy by 2050. There are opportunities to add value to the industry through innovation focusing on:

- reducing industry emissions
- the role of forestry in carbon capture and sequestration
- assisting in the substitution of emissions intense materials with low-carbon forest product alternatives
- carbon capture by wood products.

Sustainable forests for our future

Opportunities to advance research into our unique forests for a sustainable future, including:

- tree breeding and genetics
- digital technology for forest management, monitoring and inventory
- improved silvicultural management
- First Nations peoples' participation in production forest management
- natural capital accounting and maximising multiple forest benefits
- management of biodiversity, conservation and threatened species in a production landscape
- management of forest health, pests and diseases, including biosecurity
- fire management in a changing climate in the production landscape
- farm forestry in a productive landscape.

Making the most of our available wood fibre

Innovation to make the most of our wood fibre resources could focus on:

- product segregation and greater value recovery from existing resources
- wood and paper products
- innovative value adding to wood fibre
- biomaterial development
- new engineered wood solutions for construction
- improved supply chain
- transport logistics
- safety improvements, including fatigue management
- improved processing efficiency
- digital technologies, sensing machine learning and artificial intelligence applications in processing
- increasing wood fibre products contribution to the bioeconomy and circular economy
- optimising resource properties.

Contact details

You can contact the department via AFWI.research@aff.gov.au.

Additional information on the AFWI can be found on UTAS's [AFWI website](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/forestry/national/australian-forest-and-wood-innovations>